# The maximum size of a blackout that keeps every lattice rectangle identifiable

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**Abstract**

Black out some points of an $h \times m$ grid. The blackout is valid if every rectangle with corners in the grid, tilted or not, is determined by its white corners. Kagey asked for the largest size $f(h, m)$ of a valid blackout. For axis-aligned rectangles alone this is a Turán problem for bipartite graphs without cycles of length 4 and 6, and a bound of Neuwirth gives $f(h, m) \leqslant m + \lfloor h^2/4 \rfloor$ for $m \geqslant 3$. Let $m_h$ be the least width from which equality always holds. We prove that $\lfloor h^2/4 \rfloor \leqslant m_h \leqslant h^{2+o(1)}$ for every height $h \geqslant 4$. The upper bound places the columns that contain two black points at random and uses the local lemma. The same construction gives a lower bound for $f(h, m)$ at every width. An explicit construction gives equality for every $h \geqslant 3$ and every $m \geqslant h^4/16 + O(h^3)$. We also determine $f(h, m)$ for every $h \leqslant 6$ and every $m$, and for $h = 7$ and $m \geqslant 24$. Some of these small values rest on computer checks with verified certificates.

**Mathematics Subject Classifications:** 05C35, 05D40, 52C05, 68V05

## 1 Introduction

Start with an $h \times m$ grid of points and black out some of them. A game master then chooses a rectangle with corners in the grid, possibly a tilted one, and tells us which of its corners are white. The blackout is *valid* if this always determines the rectangle (Definition 5). Kagey [12] asks for the largest size $f(h, m)$ of a valid blackout. Figure 1 shows one round. The known values of $f(h, m)$ are sequence A397315 in the OEIS.

Throughout the paper we put $q_h = \lfloor h^2/4 \rfloor$ and $W_h = 1 + \lfloor (h-1)^2/4 \rfloor$.

We first look at the axis-aligned rectangles alone. Record a blackout $S$ by its *row-column graph* $G_S$, the bipartite graph that joins row $j$ to column $i$ when the point in column $i$ and row $j$ is black. For $m \geqslant 3$, the blackout distinguishes all axis-aligned rectangles exactly when $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4 or 6 (Lemma 15). Hence $|S|$ is at most the largest number of edges of a bipartite graph of girth at least 8 with parts of

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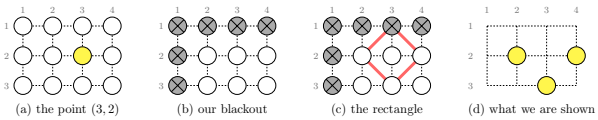



Figure 1: One round on a largest valid blackout of the $3 \times 4$ grid. Points are (column, row). Gray crossed circles are black. Panel (c) shows the red rectangle, and (d) its white corners.

sizes $h$ and $m$. Neuwirth [15, Theorem 1(ii) and Proposition 17] proved that this number is at most $m + q_h$ when $m \geqslant q_h$, and that it is attained by the following graph. Take a complete bipartite graph on the $h$ rows with parts as equal as possible. Subdivide each of its $q_h$ edges by a column, and join every remaining column to one row. In the grid, this means that $q_h$ columns contain 2 black points, on $q_h$ different row pairs, and that every other column contains 1 black point. We call such columns *doubles* and *singletons*. So $f(h, m) \leqslant m + q_h$ for $m \geqslant 3$ (Theorem 16).

The graph $G_S$ does not see the order of the columns, but the tilted rectangles do. Hence the problem for all rectangles is a problem about embeddings. We must order the columns of a subdivided triangle-free graph with pendant leaves, and choose the rows of the leaves, so that no 2 rectangles of the grid show the same white corners. Our main result says that this is possible at every height once the width is a little more than $h^2$, and that it is not possible for widths below $q_h$.

For $h \geqslant 3$ let $m_h$ be the least integer $M \geqslant 1$ such that $f(h, m) = m + q_h$ for every $m \geqslant M$. We do not know whether $f(h, m + 1) \geqslant f(h, m) + 1$ always holds. Hence equality at one width does not obviously give equality at the next width, and this is why we define $m_h$ through all larger widths. Write $\tau(n)$ for the number of divisors of $n$, and put $\tau^*(h) = \max\{\tau(n) : 1 \leqslant n \leqslant h^2\}$.

**Theorem 1** (the threshold)**.** *For every $h \geqslant 3$ the number $m_h$ exists.*

*(a) For every $h \geqslant 4$ we have $m_h \geqslant q_h$.*

*(b) There is an absolute constant $C$ such that $m_h \leqslant C\, h^2\, \tau^*(h)^2$ for every $h \geqslant 3$.*

*In particular, for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a constant $C_\varepsilon$ with $q_h \leqslant m_h \leqslant C_\varepsilon h^{2+\varepsilon}$ for every $h \geqslant 4$.*

Part (a) holds because equality needs $q_h$ doubles (Corollary 20). For part (b) we use the odd and the even rows as the 2 parts. For even $h$ every singleton is black in row 1 or row $h$. For odd $h$ we use up to 4 blocks of columns, each with its own 2 rows for the singletons. We then choose the columns of the doubles independently at random in a window of length about $q_h\, \tau^*(h)^2$. A confusion between 2 rectangles needs a few black points in a special position, and for fixed rows a divisor function bounds the number of such positions. The local lemma gives columns with no confusion that involves 2 or more doubles. The other confusions are removed by fixing the singletons in a few columns near each double. The last statement of the theorem follows from $\tau(n) \leqslant K_\delta n^\delta$

[9, Theorem 315]. The same construction with fewer doubles gives a lower bound at every width.

**Corollary 2** (every width)**.** *There is an absolute constant $C'$ such that, for every $h \geqslant 3$ and every $m \geqslant 1$,*

$$f(h,m) \;\geqslant\; m + \min\Big(q_h, \Big\lfloor \frac{m}{C'\,\tau^*(h)^2} \Big\rfloor\Big).$$

This improves on the bound $f(h,m) \geqslant m+h-1$ of Lemma 21 only for $m \geqslant C'h\,\tau^*(h)^2$, and it adds nothing for $h \leqslant 8$. The constants are large (Remark 35), so we also give an explicit construction.

**Proposition 3** (explicit construction)**.** *Let $h \geqslant 3$ and put $M_h = q_h + (q_h - 1)W_h$. Then $f(h,m) = m + q_h$ for every $m \geqslant M_h$. Hence $m_h \leqslant M_h = h^4/16 + O(h^3)$.*

Here the doubles are $W_h + 1$ columns apart. The singletons are black in row 1 or in row $h$, and they switch between these 2 rows at every double (Figure 3).

**Theorem 4** (small heights)**.** *For $2 \leqslant h \leqslant 7$ and $m \geqslant \max(h,3)$, the values of $f(h,m)-m$ are those in Table 1.*

| $h$ | $f(h,m) - m$ for $m \geqslant \max(h,3)$ |
|---|---|
| 2 | 1 |
| 3 | 2 |
| 4 | 3 for $m = 4, 5$, and 4 for $m \geqslant 6$ |
| 5 | 5 for $5 \leqslant m \leqslant 7$, and 6 for $m \geqslant 8$ |
| 6 | 6 for $m = 6, 7$, 7 for $8 \leqslant m \leqslant 11$, 8 for $12 \leqslant m \leqslant 14$, and 9 for $m \geqslant 15$ |
| 7 | 7 for $m = 7$, 8 for $m = 8$, and 12 for $m \geqslant 24$ (see Remark 40 for $m \geqslant 21$) |

Table 1: The values of Theorem 4. The last value in each row is $q_h$.

Since $f(h,m) = f(m,h)$, $f(1,m) = m$, and $f(2,2) = 4$, this determines $f(h,m)$ for every $h \leqslant 6$ and every $m$. It gives $m_4 = 6$, $m_5 = 8$, $m_6 = 15$, and $m_7 \leqslant 24$, while $q_h = 4, 6, 9, 12$ for these heights. The rows $h \leqslant 3$ and the values $f(4,m) = m + 4$ for $m \geqslant 6$ are proved by hand. The value $f(3,m) = m + 2$ was first proved in Lean by the Omega Institute [19]. All other entries are computer-assisted. Their lower bounds are explicit blackouts. For $h \geqslant 5$ the largest value is attained by one blackout extended by columns with 1 black point in a fixed row, and we reduce the validity of all extensions to one finite check (Theorem 38). Their upper bounds below $m + q_h$ are unsatisfiable SAT instances with checked LRAT certificates (Section 7).

**Related work.** Choosing white points that distinguish all rectangles is a test cover problem [4]. If we only forbid fully black axis-aligned rectangles, we get the Zarankiewicz problem, and Füredi and Simonovits [7] survey such degenerate extremal problems. Bipartite graphs without short even cycles and with parts of unequal sizes are studied by

de Caen and Székely [6], Győri [8], Hoory [11], and Naor and Verstraëte [14]. As said above, the bound $m + q_h$ for the graph and its sharpness are due to Neuwirth [15]. In this part our contribution is Lemma 15, which translates rectangles into cycles, and the description of all graphs that attain the bound (Theorem 19). Everything about tilted rectangles is new. A related problem for tilted right angles in a grid is studied by Shkredov and Solymosi [18], who consider colorings and dense subsets of a grid without tilted isosceles right triangles. A companion paper [16] counts the maximum blackouts on 2, 3, and 4 rows and proves that their counting series are rational at every fixed height. It uses Theorems 16, 19, and 4 and Proposition 3 as stated here. We do not use its results.

## 2 Definitions and a criterion for validity

The $h \times m$ grid has $h$ rows and $m$ columns. The point $(i, j)$ lies in column $i$ and row $j$, and $(1, 1)$ is the top left point (Figure 1). A *rectangle* has 4 grid points as corners and positive area, and $C(R)$ is the corner set of $R$. A rectangle is *axis-aligned* if its sides follow the grid lines, and *tilted* otherwise. A *blackout* is a set $S$ of grid points, which we call black. The other points are white. The *presentation* of a rectangle $R$ is the set $C(R) \setminus S$ of its white corners. Column $i$ has the set $B_i = \{j : (i, j) \in S\}$ of *black rows*. It is *empty*, a *singleton*, or a *double* when $|B_i|$ is 0, 1, or 2.

**Definition 5.** A blackout $S$ is *valid* if distinct rectangles have distinct presentations. We write $f(h, m)$ for the largest size of a valid blackout of the $h \times m$ grid.

Transposing the grid gives $f(h, m) = f(m, h)$. A grid with 1 row has no rectangles, so $f(1, m) = m$. The $2 \times 2$ grid has 1 rectangle, so $f(2, 2) = 4$.

**Lemma 6.** *Two rectangles $R_1$ and $R_2$ have the same presentation if and only if the set $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ is contained in $S$. Hence every subset of a valid blackout is valid.*

*Proof.* The 2 presentations agree exactly when every point that lies in just one of the sets $C(R_1)$ and $C(R_2)$ belongs to $S$. □

**Lemma 7.** *Any 3 corners of a rectangle determine it. Hence distinct rectangles have at most 2 common corners, and if they have the same presentation, then each shows at most 2 corners.*

*Proof.* Three corners form a right triangle. Its right angle is at the corner $x$ adjacent to the other 2 corners $y$ and $z$, and the fourth corner is $y + z - x$. □

**Lemma 8.** *Let the rectangles $R_1 \neq R_2$ have exactly 2 common corners $p$ and $q$. If $pq$ is a side of both or a diagonal of both, then $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ is the corner set of a rectangle.*

*Proof.* Suppose first that $pq$ is a side of both. Then the other corners are $p + u, q + u$ and $p + v, q + v$, where $u \neq v$ are nonzero and perpendicular to $q - p$. These 4 points form a rectangle with sides $q - p$ and $v - u$. Suppose now that $pq$ is a diagonal of both, with midpoint $o$. Then the other corners are $o \pm u$ and $o \pm v$ with $|u| = |v|$ and $v \neq \pm u$. The segments from $o - u$ to $o + u$ and from $o - v$ to $o + v$ have the same midpoint and the same length. Hence they are the diagonals of a rectangle. □

### 2.1 Tilted rectangles

**Lemma 9.** *A tilted rectangle $R$ has a unique corner $\ell = (x, r)$ in its smallest column. The sides from $\ell$ are $(a, -b)$ and $(c, d)$ with positive integers $a, b, c, d$ and $ac = bd$, and the corners are*

$$(x, r), \qquad (x + a,\, r - b), \qquad (x + c,\, r + d), \qquad (x + a + c,\, r - b + d). \tag{1}$$

*The rows of $R$ are $r - b$ to $r + d$. Each of the smallest row, the largest row, and the largest column of $R$ contains exactly 1 corner.*

*Proof.* No side is vertical. Two corners in the smallest column would then be opposite, and their midpoint would force the other 2 corners into that column as well. Thus $\ell$ is unique, and the 2 sides from $\ell$ point strictly to the right. Their dot product is 0, so one points up and the other down, which gives (1) and $ac = bd$. The last statement follows from (1). □

We call $a + c$ the *span* of $R$.

**Lemma 10.** *Every tilted rectangle on $h$ rows has span $a + c \leqslant W_h$.*

*Proof.* The rectangle fits in $h$ rows, so $b + d \leqslant h - 1$. Also $(a - 1)(c - 1) \geqslant 0$. Hence $a + c \leqslant ac + 1 = bd + 1 \leqslant W_h$, where we used that $bd \leqslant \lfloor (b + d)^2/4 \rfloor$ for integers. □

**Lemma 11.** *Let $R$ be a tilted rectangle of the $h \times m$ grid.*

*(F1) $R$ has at most 1 corner in row 1 and at most 1 corner in row $h$.*

*(F2) If $R$ has corners in row 1 and in row $h$, then they are opposite.*

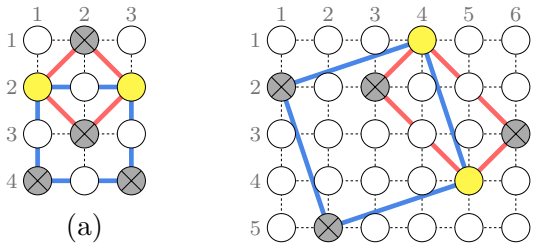
*(F3) Two corners of $R$ in one column are opposite, and so are 2 corners in one row.*

*Proof.* (F1) follows from Lemma 9, since a corner in row 1 lies in the smallest row of $R$. (F3) holds because a vertical or a horizontal side would make $R$ axis-aligned. For (F2), suppose that the 2 corners are adjacent. The other 2 corners are their translates by a nonzero vector $n = (n_1, n_2)$ perpendicular to the side. Staying in the grid requires $n_2 \geqslant 0$ at row 1 and $n_2 \leqslant 0$ at row $h$. Hence $n$ is horizontal and the side is vertical, a contradiction. □

### 2.2 Mixed pairs

By Lemma 8, the remaining way for 2 rectangles to share 2 corners is the following.

**Definition 12.** A *mixed pair* is a pair $(R_1, R_2)$ of rectangles with exactly 2 common corners $p$ and $q$ such that $pq$ is a side of $R_1$ and a diagonal of $R_2$. Its *support* is $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$. The support consists of the side $AB$ of $R_1$ opposite to $pq$ and of the diagonal $CD$ of $R_2$ other than $pq$ (Figure 2).




(a) (b)

Figure 2: Two mixed pairs. The common corners $p, q$ are yellow, $R_1$ is blue, and $R_2$ is red. If the 4 points of the support are black, then both rectangles show exactly $p$ and $q$.

In a mixed pair the rectangles are not both axis-aligned, since a side of an axis-aligned rectangle is horizontal or vertical and a diagonal is not. We record the equations of a support.

**Lemma 13.** *Let $A, B, C, D$ be the support of a mixed pair as in Definition 12. Then there is a nonzero integer vector $n$ such that*

$$n \cdot (B-A) = 0, \qquad C+D = A+B+2n, \qquad |D-C| = |B-A|, \qquad D-C \neq \pm(B-A).$$

*Proof.* Name the common corners so that $p = A+n$ and $q = B+n$. Then $n$ is a nonzero integer vector perpendicular to the side $AB$. The diagonals $pq$ and $CD$ of $R_2$ have the same midpoint and the same length, which gives the next 2 equations. If $D - C = \pm(B-A) = \pm(q-p)$, then $\{C, D\} = \{p, q\}$. □

**Lemma 14** (criterion)**.** *Let $S$ be a blackout of the $h \times m$ grid. Suppose that*

*(i) the graph $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4 or 6,*

*(ii) no tilted rectangle has 3 or more black corners, and*

*(iii) no mixed pair has all 4 points of its support black.*

*Then $S$ is valid.*

*Proof.* Suppose that $R_1 \neq R_2$ have the same presentation. By Lemma 6, the set $D = C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ is black. By (i) and Lemma 15 below, whose proof does not use this lemma, the rectangles are not both axis-aligned. By Lemma 7 they have at most 2 common corners. With no common corner, both rectangles are fully black. With 1 common corner, both have 3 black corners. One of them is tilted, so both cases contradict (ii). Suppose finally that they have 2 common corners $p$ and $q$. If $pq$ is a side of both or a diagonal of both, then $D$ is the corner set of a rectangle $R_3$ by Lemma 8, and $R_3$ is fully black. If $R_3$ is tilted, this contradicts (ii). If $R_3$ is axis-aligned, its corners give a cycle of length 4 in $G_S$, which contradicts (i). Otherwise $(R_1, R_2)$ or $(R_2, R_1)$ is a mixed pair with support $D$, which contradicts (iii). □

## 3 The row bound and the equality structure

A blackout $S$ is *axis-valid* if distinct axis-aligned rectangles have distinct presentations. Recall that the row-column graph $G_S$ joins row $r_j$ to column $c_i$ for each black point $(i, j)$.

**Lemma 15.** *If $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4 or 6, then $S$ is axis-valid. The converse holds for $m \geqslant 3$.*

*Proof.* Let $R_1 \neq R_2$ be axis-aligned with the same presentation, so that $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2) \subseteq S$. They cannot share opposite corners. Hence their common corners lie in one row or in one column, and by symmetry we can assume that they lie in one row $a$. With no common corner, $R_1$ is fully black, which gives a cycle of length 4. With 2 common corners $(x, a)$ and $(y, a)$, the other rows $b \neq c$ of $R_1$ and $R_2$ give the cycle $r_b\, c_x\, r_c\, c_y$. With just 1 common corner $(x, a)$, write $R_1 = \{x, y\} \times \{a, b\}$ and $R_2 = \{x, z\} \times \{a, c\}$. Then $y \neq z$ and $b \neq c$, and the 6 black points give the cycle $r_a\, c_y\, r_b\, c_x\, r_c\, c_z$.

Conversely, let $m \geqslant 3$. A cycle $r_j\, c_i\, r_{j'}\, c_{i'}$ gives the rectangles $\{i, w\} \times \{j, j'\}$ and $\{i', w\} \times \{j, j'\}$ for a third column $w$, and both show exactly their white corners in column $w$. A cycle $r_a\, c_x\, r_b\, c_y\, r_c\, c_z$ gives the rectangles $\{x, y\} \times \{a, b\}$ and $\{y, z\} \times \{a, c\}$. Both are black except possibly at $(y, a)$. □

**Theorem 16** (row bound)**.** *Let $m \geqslant 3$. Every axis-valid blackout of the $h \times m$ grid has at most $m + q_h$ points. Hence $f(h, m) \leqslant m + q_h$.*

In graph terms this is the bound of Neuwirth [15, Theorem 1(ii) and Proposition 17] for bipartite graphs without cycles of length 4 and 6, which he states for $m \geqslant q_h$. His proof contracts each column to the pairs of its black rows. The contracted graph on the rows is triangle-free with at most $q_h$ edges, so at most $q_h$ columns have 2 or more black points [15, Proposition 3], and he bounds the number of edges at these columns by his cubic inequality [15, Theorem 1(i)]. He shows that the bound is attained, but he does not describe all graphs that attain it. His Remark 18 gives the maximum for $h \leqslant 5$. It is $m + h - 1$ for $h \leqslant 3$, $m + 4$ for $h = 4 \leqslant m$, and $m + 6$ for $h = 5 < m$. For example the maximum for the graph is 8 when $h = m = 4$, while $f(4, 4) = 7$. We give a short proof by Mantel's theorem [13] because we need its cases of equality. We join the black rows $B_i$ of each nonempty column by a tree $T_i$, so that the graph on the rows stays triangle-free when a column has 3 or more black rows. Let $H$ be the union of these trees, a graph on the $h$ rows.

**Lemma 17.** *Let $m \geqslant 3$ and let $S$ be axis-valid. For any choice of the trees, $H$ is simple and triangle-free, and $e(H) = |S| - t$, where $t$ is the number of nonempty columns.*

*Proof.* By Lemma 15, $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4 or 6. A repeated edge of $H$ would put the same row pair in 2 columns, which gives a cycle of length 4. Hence $e(H) = \sum_i (|B_i| - 1) = |S| - t$. Suppose that $H$ contains a triangle $r_a r_b r_c$. Its edges do not all belong to one tree. If 2 columns $i, i'$ supply them, then 2 of $a, b, c$ belong to $B_i \cap B_{i'}$, which again gives a cycle of length 4. If 3 columns supply them, we get the cycle $r_a\, c_i\, r_b\, c_{i'}\, r_c\, c_{i''}$ of length 6. □

**Lemma 18** (Mantel)**.** *Let $H$ be a simple triangle-free graph on $h$ vertices. Let a vertex of maximum degree $\Delta$ have neighbor set $\Gamma$, and let $\Omega$ be the set of the other $h-\Delta$ vertices, which spans $e(\Omega)$ edges. Then*

$$e(H) = \sum_{b\in\Omega} d(b) - e(\Omega) \leqslant (h-\Delta)\Delta - e(\Omega) \leqslant q_h.$$

*Proof.* The set $\Gamma$ is independent, so every edge meets $\Omega$. The degree sum over $\Omega$ counts the edges inside $\Omega$ twice. Then use $d(b) \leqslant \Delta$ and $(h-\Delta)\Delta \leqslant q_h$. □

*Proof of Theorem 16.* Lemmas 17 and 18 give $|S| = t + e(H) \leqslant m + q_h$. □

**Theorem 19** (equality structure)**.** *Let $h \geqslant 4$ and $m \geqslant 3$. A blackout of the $h \times m$ grid with $m + q_h$ points is axis-valid if and only if*

*(a) every column is a singleton or a double,*

*(b) the $q_h$ doubles have distinct row pairs, and*

*(c) these pairs are the edges of a complete bipartite graph on the rows with parts of sizes $\lfloor h/2 \rfloor$ and $\lceil h/2 \rceil$.*

*Proof.* Let $S$ be axis-valid with $m + q_h$ points. Equality in the proof of the row bound forces $t = m$, $e(\Omega) = 0$, $(h-\Delta)\Delta = q_h$, and $d(b) = \Delta$ for every $b \in \Omega$. Thus $H$ is the complete bipartite graph between $\Gamma$ and $\Omega$, as in (c), for every choice of the trees. Suppose that $|B_i| \geqslant 3$. Then $T_i$ has a vertex $v$ with 2 neighbors $u$ and $w$, which lie in one part. Since $h \geqslant 4$, the part of $v$ contains another vertex $z$. Replace the edge $vw$ of $T_i$ by $uw$. This gives another tree on $B_i$, and the new graph $H$ contains $uz$, $wz$, and $uw$, which contradicts Lemma 17. This proves (a). The tree edges are now the row pairs of the doubles, which gives (b) and (c).

Conversely, assume (a) to (c). By (a) and (b), no 2 columns share 2 black rows, so $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4. A cycle $r_a\, c_x\, r_b\, c_y\, r_c\, c_z$ needs doubles on $\{a, b\}$, $\{b, c\}$, and $\{a, c\}$, which contradicts (c). Now apply Lemma 15. □

The graph $G_S$ of such a blackout is the extremal graph of Neuwirth from the introduction.

**Corollary 20.** *Let $h \geqslant 4$ and $3 \leqslant m < q_h$. Then $f(h, m) \leqslant m + q_h - 1$. Hence $m_h \geqslant q_h$ for $h \geqslant 4$.*

*Proof.* A valid blackout with $m + q_h$ points would have $q_h$ doubles in different columns by Theorem 19. For the last statement, note that $q_h - 1 \geqslant 3$. □

This proves Theorem 1(a). We end the section with a lower bound that holds on every grid.

**Lemma 21** (boundary cross)**.** *The first row and the first column of the $h \times m$ grid form a valid blackout. Hence $f(h, m) \geqslant h + m - 1$.*

*Proof.* The graph $G_S$ is a tree, so (i) of Lemma 14 holds. Let $R$ be a tilted rectangle with corners (1). By Lemma 9, its only possible corner in column 1 is $\ell$, and its only possible corner in row 1 is $\ell + (a, -b)$. Hence (ii) holds, and 2 black corners of a tilted rectangle are always adjacent. Let $(R_1, R_2)$ be a mixed pair with black support $A, B, C, D$. The corners $C, D$ of $R_2$ are black and opposite, so $R_2$ is axis-aligned and $R_1$ is tilted. Then $\{A, B\} = \{\ell, \ell + (a, -b)\}$ with $\ell = (1, 1+b)$, and the common corners $p = (1+c, 1+b+d)$ and $q = (1 + a + c, 1 + d)$ lie in columns and rows at least 2. The other corners $C, D$ of the axis-aligned rectangle with diagonal $pq$ also lie in columns and rows at least 2, so they are white, a contradiction. Thus (iii) holds. □

## 4 An explicit construction at every height

We now prove Proposition 3. We place the doubles far apart and let the singletons between them be black in a boundary row. Call a singleton a *sea* if its black point lies in row 1 or in row $h$.

**Proposition 22** (alternating seas)**.** *Let $h \geqslant 3$ and let $H$ be a triangle-free graph on the rows with edges $e_1, \dots, e_q$, where $q \geqslant 1$. Let $Z$ be the blackout of the $h \times m$ grid with the following columns. The columns $p_1 < \cdots < p_q$ are doubles, where column $p_j$ is black exactly in the 2 rows of $e_j$ and $p_{j+1} - p_j \geqslant W_h + 1$. Every other column is a sea. The seas to the left of $p_1$ are black in row 1, and the row of the seas switches between 1 and $h$ at every double. Then $Z$ is valid and $|Z| = m + q$.*

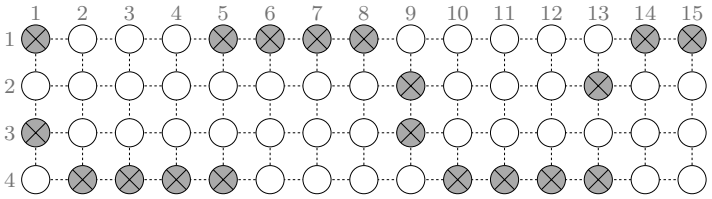



Figure 3: The blackout of Proposition 22 for $h = 4$ and $m = 15$, with the 4 edges of the complete bipartite graph between $\{1, 2\}$ and $\{3, 4\}$. Here $W_4 + 1 = 4$.

*Proof of Proposition 3.* Theorem 16 gives the upper bound. Take $H$ to be the complete bipartite graph with parts of sizes $\lfloor h/2 \rfloor$ and $\lceil h/2 \rceil$, so $q = q_h$, and place the doubles at $p_j = 1 + (j-1)(W_h + 1)$. The last double is in column $1 + (q_h - 1)(W_h + 1) = M_h$. Hence Proposition 22 gives a valid blackout with $m + q_h$ points for every $m \geqslant M_h$. □

*Proof of Proposition 22.* Each double adds 1 point to a column, so $|Z| = m + q$. We check the 3 conditions of Lemma 14.

*Condition (i).* Only doubles have 2 black rows, and their pairs are distinct, so $G_Z$ has no cycle of length 4. A cycle $r_a\, c_x\, r_b\, c_y\, r_c\, c_z$ would need doubles on $\{a, b\}$, $\{b, c\}$, and $\{a, c\}$, a triangle in $H$.

*The black corners of a tilted rectangle.* Let $R$ be a tilted rectangle. In this proof, *the columns of* $R$ are all columns from its smallest to its largest column, not only the columns of its corners. The span of $R$ is at most $W_h$ (Lemma 10), so its columns contain at most 1 double. With no double, all black points in the columns of $R$ lie in one boundary row, and $R$ has at most 1 black corner by (F1). Otherwise, shift the double to column 0 and write its black rows as $a < b$. Reflecting the rows if needed, we can assume that the seas in the columns of $R$ are black in row 1 to the left of column 0 and in row $h$ to the right.

Let $K$ be the set of black corners of $R$. By (F1), the elements of $K$ can only be one point $u = (x_1, 1)$ with $x_1 < 0$, one point $v = (x_2, h)$ with $x_2 > 0$, and points $(0, c)$ with $c \in \{a, b\}$. A corner $(0, 1)$ excludes $u$, and a corner $(0, h)$ excludes $v$. We now list the sets $K$ with $|K| \geqslant 2$. In each case we find the other corners of $R$.

(a) $K = \{u, v\}$. These corners are opposite by (F2). The other diagonal has midpoint $\left(\frac{x_1+x_2}{2}, \frac{1+h}{2}\right)$ and endpoints at this midpoint plus and minus a vector $w$ with $|w|^2 = \frac{1}{4}\big((x_2 - x_1)^2 + (h-1)^2\big)$. By (F1) the endpoints lie in rows 2 to $h-1$. Hence $|w_2| \leqslant \frac{h-3}{2}$ and $w_1^2 > \frac{1}{4}(x_2 - x_1)^2$. So one endpoint lies to the left of column $x_1$ and the other to the right of column $x_2$.

(b) $K = \{(0, a), (0, b)\}$. These corners are opposite by (F3). The other diagonal has midpoint $\left(0, \frac{a+b}{2}\right)$ and length $b - a$, and it is not vertical. Hence its endpoints lie in columns $-w_1$ and $w_1$ for some $w_1 \neq 0$, and in rows strictly between $a$ and $b$.

(c) $K = \{u, d\}$ with $d = (0, c)$, and $u, d$ are opposite. Here $c \geqslant 2$ by (F1). The other diagonal has midpoint $\left(\frac{x_1}{2}, \frac{1+c}{2}\right)$ and endpoints at this midpoint plus and minus a vector $w$ with $|w|^2 = \frac{1}{4}\big(x_1^2 + (c-1)^2\big)$. The endpoints are not in row 1 by (F1). They are not in row $h$ by (F2), since the corner opposite to $u$ is $d$. They are not in column 0 by (F3), for the same reason. Since their rows are at least 2, we get $|w_2| \leqslant \frac{c-3}{2}$. In particular $c \geqslant 3$, and $w_1^2 > \frac{1}{4}x_1^2$. Thus one endpoint lies to the right of column 0 and the other to the left of column $x_1$.

(d) $K = \{u, d\}$ with $d = (0, c)$, and $u, d$ are adjacent. Again $c \geqslant 2$. The side $d - u$ is $(|x_1|, c-1)$, and the other corners are $u + n$ and $d + n$ with $n = t\,(-(c-1), |x_1|)$ for some real $t \neq 0$. The corner $u + n$ lies in row $1 + t|x_1|$, so $t > 0$. Hence both corners lie in columns to the left of column 0 and in rows at least 2.

(e) $K = \{v, d\}$ with $d = (0, c)$. The half turn $(x, j) \mapsto (-x, h + 1 - j)$ exchanges the 2 seas and fixes column 0. It reduces this case to (c) or (d).

(f) $|K| \geqslant 3$. This is impossible. If $K$ contains $(0, a)$ and $(0, b)$, then the other 2 corners lie in rows strictly between $a$ and $b$ by (b), so they are neither $u$ nor $v$, and they are not in column 0. Otherwise $K = \{u, d, v\}$ with $d = (0, c)$. Then $u$ and $v$ are opposite by (F2) and $d$ is adjacent to both. So $(u - d) \cdot (v - d) = 0$, that is $x_1 x_2 = (c-1)(h-c)$. The left side is negative and the right side is not.

In (a) to (d), the 2 other corners lie in columns different from 0 and in rows 2 to $h-1$, or to the left of column 0 and in rows at least 2. The seas in these columns are black only

in row 1 or only in row $h$, so the 2 other corners are white. By (e) the same holds in the reflected cases. We have proved the following 3 statements for a tilted rectangle $R$.

(1) $R$ has at most 2 black corners. Hence condition (ii) holds.

(2) If $R$ has 2 opposite black corners, then its 2 white corners lie in rows 2 to $h-1$, one of them to the left and the other to the right of the double in the columns of $R$.

(3) If $R$ has 2 adjacent black corners, then both white corners of $R$ lie on one side of the double in the columns of $R$. On this side the seas in the columns of $R$ are black in one boundary row, and the white corners are not in that row.

*Condition (iii).* Let $(R_1, R_2)$ be a mixed pair with common corners $p, q$ whose support is black. A tilted rectangle of the pair has 2 black corners in the support, so its corners $p, q$ are white by (1).

Suppose that $R_1$ is axis-aligned. Then $R_2$ is tilted with 2 opposite black corners. By (2), $p$ and $q$ lie in different columns $x < z$ on the 2 sides of the double of $R_2$. So the side $pq$ of $R_1$ is horizontal. The other 2 corners of $R_1$ are black points of the columns $x$ and $z$ in a common row. But these columns are seas, one black only in row 1 and the other only in row $h$, a contradiction.

Suppose that $R_2$ is axis-aligned. Then $R_1$ is tilted with 2 adjacent black corners. By (3), $p = (x, j)$ and $q = (z, k)$ lie in sea columns that are black only in one boundary row $\sigma$, and $j, k \neq \sigma$. The other corners of $R_2$ are $(x, k)$ and $(z, j)$, which are white, a contradiction.

Suppose finally that both are tilted. The side opposite to $pq$ in $R_1$ is black, so (3) applies to $R_1$. Let $D_1$ be the column of the double in the columns of $R_1$. Then $p$ and $q$ lie on one side of column $D_1$. The diagonal of $R_2$ other than $pq$ is black, so (2) applies to $R_2$. Let $D_2$ be the column of the double in the columns of $R_2$. Then $D_2$ lies strictly between the columns of $p$ and $q$. Hence $D_2 \neq D_1$, and $D_2$ is a second double in the columns of $R_1$, a contradiction. Thus (iii) holds, and $Z$ is valid by Lemma 14. □

*Remark* 23. The proof uses the spacing $W_h + 1$ only to keep 2 doubles out of the columns of one tilted rectangle. The spacing $W_h$ is not always enough. Take the complete bipartite graph between the rows $1, \dots, \lfloor h/2 \rfloor$ and the other rows, with the doubles in lexicographic order of their row pairs. Then the blackout with spacing $W_h$ is valid for $h = 3, 5, 7$ and not valid for $h = 4, 6, 8$. Note that $M_5 = 31$, while $m_5 = 8$.

## 5 The threshold is nearly quadratic

In this section we prove Theorem 1(b). A *parity edge* is a pair $\{r, s\}$ of rows with $r$ odd and $s$ even. There are $q_h$ parity edges, and they are the edges of a complete bipartite graph as in Theorem 19(c). Our blackouts have one double for each parity edge and a singleton in every other column. All singletons of a long block of columns are black in one of 2 fixed rows, which we call the *sea rows*.

### 5.1 Obstructions

It is convenient to work in the strip $\Sigma_h = \mathbb{Z} \times \{1, \dots, h\}$. A rectangle *of the strip* has its corners in $\Sigma_h$. The lemmas of Section 2 hold in the strip with the same proofs. A *configuration* is a subset of $\Sigma_h$, whose points we call black.

**Definition 24.** We use 3 kinds of *obstructions*.

(1) A *corner triple* consists of 3 corners of a tilted rectangle of the strip.

(2) A *mixed quadruple* is the support $\{A, B, C, D\}$ of a mixed pair of the strip whose side $AB$ is not vertical.

(3) Let $R$ be a tilted rectangle of the strip that has a vertical diagonal $pq$, where the rows of $p$ and $q$ have different parity. The other 2 corners of $R$ form a *rival pair*.

A configuration *contains* an obstruction if all points of the obstruction are black.

The points of an obstruction always lie in $2W_h + 1$ consecutive columns. For corner triples and rival pairs this holds because a tilted rectangle has span at most $W_h$. In a mixed pair $(R_1, R_2)$ with common corners $p, q$, at least one rectangle is tilted. If both are tilted, they share the corner $p$ and have span at most $W_h$. If $R_2$ is axis-aligned, its columns are those of $p$ and $q$, which are columns of $R_1$. If $R_1$ is axis-aligned and $pq$ is not vertical, then $pq$ is horizontal, and the columns of $R_1$ are again those of $p$ and $q$. A mixed pair with a vertical side $pq$ does not give a mixed quadruple. It gives a rival pair (Lemma 25).

**Lemma 25** (reduction)**.** *Let $S$ be a blackout of the $h \times m$ grid. Suppose that every column is a singleton or a double, that the doubles have distinct row pairs, and that these pairs are parity edges. If $S$ contains no obstruction, then $S$ is valid.*

*Proof.* We check the conditions of Lemma 14. The graph $G_S$ has no cycle of length 4 because the doubles have distinct pairs. A cycle of length 6 would need 3 doubles whose pairs form a triangle, but the parity edges form a bipartite graph. A tilted rectangle with 3 black corners gives a corner triple. Let $(R_1, R_2)$ be a mixed pair with common corners $p, q$ and black support $A, B, C, D$. If the side $AB$ is not vertical, the support is a mixed quadruple. Suppose that $AB$ is vertical. Then $A$ and $B$ are 2 black points of one column, so their rows form a parity edge. The side $pq$ of $R_1$ is vertical with the same 2 rows. Now $pq$ is a diagonal of $R_2$, so $R_2$ is tilted, and $\{C, D\}$ is a rival pair. □

The next 3 lemmas show that some simple configurations contain no obstructions.

**Lemma 26** (rival pairs)**.** *Let $\{C, D\}$ be a rival pair with $C$ in row $c$, $D$ in row $c'$, and $c \leqslant c'$. Then $c' - c$ is odd, and there is an integer $j \geqslant 1$ with*

$$c - j \geqslant 1, \qquad c' + j \leqslant h, \qquad 4j(c' - c + j) = (C_x - D_x)^2,$$

*where $C_x$ and $D_x$ are the columns of $C$ and $D$. In particular, no point of a rival pair lies in row 1 or in row $h$, and the 2 points lie in rows of different parity.*

*Proof.* Let $R$ and $pq$ be as in Definition 24(3), and let $L$ be the length of $pq$. Then $L$ is an odd integer. The diagonals $pq$ and $CD$ have the same midpoint and the same length. Put $t = C_x - D_x$ and $d = c' - c$, so that $L^2 = t^2 + d^2$. Here $t \neq 0$, since $CD$ is not vertical, and so $L > d$. The rows of $p$ and $q$ are $\frac{1}{2}(c + c' - L)$ and $\frac{1}{2}(c + c' + L)$. They are integers, so $L - d$ is even. Write $L = d + 2j$ with $j \geqslant 1$. Then $d$ is odd, the rows of $p$ and $q$ are $c - j$ and $c' + j$, and $t^2 = L^2 - d^2 = 4j(d + j)$. □

**Lemma 27** (two sea rows)**.** *Let $g$ be an even integer with $2 \leqslant g \leqslant h$ and $2g - 1 > h$. No obstruction has all its points in the rows 1 and $g$.*

*Proof.* Suppose that 3 corners of a tilted rectangle $R$ lie in the rows 1 and $g$. Then 2 of them lie in one row $y_0$, and they are opposite by (F3). So no other corner lies in row $y_0$, and the third corner lies in the other row $y_1$. The center of $R$ is in row $y_0$, so the fourth corner is in row $2y_0 - y_1$. This row is $2 - g < 1$ or $2g - 1 > h$, a contradiction.

Let $\{A, B, C, D\}$ be a mixed quadruple in the rows 1 and $g$, and let $n = (n_1, n_2)$ be as in Lemma 13. Write $B - A = (x, y)$, where $x \neq 0$. The equation $C + D = A + B + 2n$ shows that the rows of $C$ and $D$ have the same sum modulo 2 as the rows of $A$ and $B$. Since $1 + g$ is odd, either both pairs lie in one row each, or both pairs meet both rows. In the first case $y = 0$, so $n_1 x = 0$ gives $n_1 = 0$, and $D - C$ is horizontal with $|D - C| = |x|$. Then $D - C = \pm(B - A)$, a contradiction. In the second case the row sums are equal, so $n_2 = 0$. Then $n_1 x = 0$ gives $n = 0$, a contradiction.

By Lemma 26, a rival pair has no point in row 1 and does not lie in one row. □

A *chain* is a set of points of $\mathbb{Z}^2$ in which any 2 points $P, P'$ satisfy $P \leqslant P'$ or $P' \leqslant P$ in both coordinates.

**Lemma 28** (chains)**.** *A chain contains no corner triple and no mixed quadruple.*

*Proof.* Let $Q_0, Q_1, Q_2$ be a corner triple with the right angle at $Q_0$. The vectors $Q_1 - Q_0$ and $Q_2 - Q_0$ are sides of a tilted rectangle, so all their coordinates are nonzero. In a chain, each of them has 2 positive or 2 negative coordinates. Then their dot product is not 0, a contradiction.

Let $\{A, B, C, D\}$ be a mixed quadruple in a chain, with $n$ as in Lemma 13. We can name the points so that $A \leqslant B$ and $C \leqslant D$. Put $U = B - A$ and $\varphi(P) = (P - A) \cdot U$. Then $\varphi(A) = 0$ and $\varphi(B) = |U|^2$. The equations $C + D = A + B + 2n$ and $n \cdot U = 0$ give $\varphi(C) + \varphi(D) = |U|^2$. Also $|\varphi(D) - \varphi(C)| = |(D - C) \cdot U| < |U|^2$, because $|D - C| = |U|$ and $D - C \neq \pm U$. Hence $0 < \varphi(P) < |U|^2$ for $P \in \{C, D\}$. The coordinates of $U$ are nonnegative. So a point $P \leqslant A$ has $\varphi(P) \leqslant 0$, and a point $P \geqslant B$ has $\varphi(P) \geqslant |U|^2$. Since the 4 points form a chain, we get $A \leqslant C \leqslant D \leqslant B$. Then $0 \leqslant D - C \leqslant B - A$ in both coordinates, and $|D - C| = |B - A|$ forces $D - C = B - A$, a contradiction. □

Finally we count obstructions with given rows. Recall that $\tau^*(h) = \max\{\tau(n) : 1 \leqslant n \leqslant h^2\}$.

**Lemma 29** (counting)**.** *Fix rows $y_0, y_1, y_2, y_3$.*

(a) *There are at most* $2\tau^*(h)$ *triples* $(Q_0, Q_1, Q_2)$ *such that* $\{Q_0, Q_1, Q_2\}$ *is a corner triple with the right angle at* $Q_0$*, the point* $Q_i$ *lies in row* $y_i$*, and* $Q_0$ *lies in column* 0*.*

(b) *There are at most* $4\tau^*(h)$ *quadruples* $(A, B, C, D)$ *that form a mixed quadruple with side* $AB$ *and diagonal* $CD$*, with these points in the rows* $y_0, y_1, y_2, y_3$ *and with* $A$ *in column* 0*.*

(c) *There are at most* $2\tau^*(h)$ *rival pairs* $\{C, D\}$ *with* $C = (0, y_0)$ *and* $D$ *in row* $y_1$*.*

*Proof.* (a) Write $Q_1 - Q_0 = (x_1, y_1 - y_0)$ and $Q_2 - Q_0 = (x_2, y_2 - y_0)$. All 4 coordinates are nonzero, and $x_1 x_2 = -(y_1 - y_0)(y_2 - y_0)$. So $x_1$ is a positive or negative divisor of a fixed integer $k$ with $1 \leqslant |k| \leqslant h^2$, and $x_1$ determines $x_2$.

(b) Let $n = (n_1, n_2)$ be as in Lemma 13, and write $B - A = (x, y)$ and $D - C = (z, v)$. The rows fix $y$, $v$, and $n_2$, and we have $x \neq 0$, $n_1 x = -n_2 y$, and $x^2 + y^2 = z^2 + v^2$. Suppose first that $y \neq 0$. Then $n_2 \neq 0$, since otherwise $n = 0$. So $x$ is a divisor of the integer $n_2 y$, where $1 \leqslant |n_2 y| \leqslant h^2$. There are at most $2\tau^*(h)$ such $x$. Each of them determines $n_1$ and allows at most 2 values of $z$. Suppose now that $y = 0$. Then $n_1 = 0$ and $x^2 - z^2 = v^2$. Here $v \neq 0$, since otherwise $D - C = \pm(B - A)$. Hence $|x| - |z|$ is a divisor of $v^2$, and it determines $|x|$ and $|z|$. This gives at most $4\tau(v^2) \leqslant 4\tau^*(h)$ pairs $(x, z)$. In both cases $x$, $z$, and $n$ determine $B = A + (x, y)$ and then $C$ and $D$, by $C + D = A + B + 2n$.

(c) By Lemma 26, the column $t$ of $D$ satisfies $t^2 + d^2 = L^2$ with $d = |y_1 - y_0| \geqslant 1$ and an integer $L$. Then $L - |t|$ is a divisor of $d^2$, and it determines $|t|$. □

### 5.2 One double

Fix an even integer $g$ with $2 \leqslant g \leqslant h$ and $2g - 1 > h$. The sea rows are 1 and $g$.

**Definition 30.** A parity edge $e = \{r, s\}$ with $r$ odd is *good for* $g$ if $r \leqslant g$, $s \leqslant g$, and $j(g - r + j)$ is not a perfect square for any integer $j$ with $1 \leqslant j \leqslant \min(r - 1, h - g)$. Its *gadget* is the configuration

$$G_e = \{(x, 1) : x < 0\} \cup \{(0, r), (0, s)\} \cup \{(x, g) : x > 0\}.$$

An obstruction is *private to* $e$ if it has a point in column 0, all its points in column 0 lie in the rows $r$ and $s$, and all its other points lie in the rows 1 and $g$. Let $A_e$ be the set of integers $a \neq 0$ such that some corner triple or mixed quadruple private to $e$ has a point in column $a$.

The set $A_e$ lists the columns near a double on $e$ whose singletons can take part in a confusion with this double alone. We will fix the singletons in these columns as in the gadget.

**Lemma 31** (one double)**.** *Let* $e$ *be good for* $g$*.*

(a) *We have* $|A_e| \leqslant 2^{14}\,\tau^*(h)$*, and* $|a| \leqslant 2W_h$ *for every* $a \in A_e$*.*

*(b) The gadget $G_e$ contains no corner triple and no mixed quadruple.*

*(c) No rival pair consists of a point $(0, c)$ with $c \in e$ and a point in row 1 or $g$.*

*Proof.* (a) In a private obstruction every point lies in one of the 4 rows $r, s, 1, g$. By Lemma 29(a), there are at most $4^3 \cdot 2\tau^*(h)$ corner triples with rows in this set, up to horizontal translations. Each of them has at most 3 translates with a point in column 0, and each translate has at most 2 other columns. This gives at most $768\,\tau^*(h)$ elements of $A_e$. In the same way, Lemma 29(b) gives at most $4^4 \cdot 4\tau^*(h) \cdot 4 \cdot 3 = 12288\,\tau^*(h)$ elements. The bound on $|a|$ holds because an obstruction lies in $2W_h + 1$ consecutive columns.

(b) Since $r, s \leqslant g$, the gadget is a chain. Apply Lemma 28.

(c) Let $\{(0, c), D\}$ be such a rival pair. By Lemma 26, $D$ is not in row 1. So $D$ is in row $g$, and $c$ is odd, that is $c = r < g$. Lemma 26 gives an integer $j$ with $1 \leqslant j \leqslant \min(r-1, h-g)$ such that $4j(g-r+j)$ is a perfect square. Then $j(g-r+j)$ is a perfect square, which contradicts Definition 30. □

### 5.3 Many doubles

Let $\mathcal{E}$ be a set of parity edges that are good for $g$. We give each $e \in \mathcal{E}$ a column $X_e$, and we put $A_e^* = A_e \cup \{0\}$. For a set $L \subseteq \mathcal{E}$ with $2 \leqslant |L| \leqslant 4$, we say that the columns $(X_e)_{e \in L}$ are *bad* if at least one of the following holds.

(B1) $L = \{e, f\}$ and the sets $X_e + A_e^*$ and $X_f + A_f^*$ intersect.

(B2) $L = \{e, f\}$ and $\{(X_e, c), (X_f, c')\}$ is a rival pair for some $c \in e$ and $c' \in f$.

(B3) The columns $X_e$ with $e \in L$ are distinct, and there is a corner triple or a mixed quadruple $Q$ with the following 2 properties. Every point of $Q$ in a column $X_e$ with $e \in L$ lies in a row of $e$, and every other point of $Q$ lies in row 1 or $g$. For every $e \in L$, at least one point of $Q$ lies in column $X_e$.

**Lemma 32** (placement)**.** *There is an absolute constant $c_0$ with the following property. Let $\mathcal{E}$ be a set of $n \geqslant 1$ parity edges that are good for $g$, and let $N \geqslant c_0\, n\, \tau^*(h)^2$ be an integer. Then there are columns $X_e \in \{1, \dots, N\}$ for $e \in \mathcal{E}$ such that $(X_e)_{e \in L}$ is not bad for any $L \subseteq \mathcal{E}$ with $2 \leqslant |L| \leqslant 4$.*

*Proof.* Choose the $X_e$ independently and uniformly from $\{1, \dots, N\}$, and let $E_L$ be the event that $(X_e)_{e \in L}$ is bad. Write $\tau^* = \tau^*(h)$.

We first bound $\Pr(E_L)$. Fix one edge $e_0 \in L$. Each of the conditions below fixes the differences $X_e - X_{e_0}$ for all $e \in L$, so it holds with probability at most $N^{-(|L|-1)}$. For (B1) there are at most $(|A_e| + 1)(|A_f| + 1) \leqslant 2^{30}\tau^{*2}$ possible differences $X_f - X_e$, by Lemma 31(a). For (B2) there are 4 choices of $(c, c')$. By Lemma 29(c), the pair $\{(X_e, c), (X_f, c')\}$ is a rival pair only if $X_f - X_e$ is one of at most $2\tau^*$ integers.

For (B3), let $Q$ be as in (B3). If $Q$ is a corner triple, list its points as $(Q_0, Q_1, Q_2)$ with the right angle at $Q_0$. If $Q$ is a mixed quadruple, list them as $(A, B, C, D)$ with the side $AB$ and the diagonal $CD$. Give each point of the list a *type*. A point in a column

$X_e$ with $e \in L$ gets the type $(e, c)$, where $c \in e$ is its row. This is well defined because the columns $X_e$ are distinct. Every other point gets its row, which is 1 or $g$, as its type. There are at most 10 types, so there are at most $10^3 + 10^4$ lists of types, and every $e \in L$ occurs in the list of $Q$. Now fix a list of types in which every $e \in L$ occurs. It fixes the rows of the points. By Lemma 29(a) and (b), at most $4\tau^*$ lists of points $Q^*$ of the same kind have these rows and their first point in column 0, and $Q$ is a horizontal translate of one of them. Fix $Q^*$ as well. If $Q$ is the translate of $Q^*$ by $x$ columns, then $X_e$ is $x$ plus the column of every point of $Q^*$ of type $(e, c)$. Hence $Q^*$ and the list of types determine all differences $X_e - X_{e_0}$ with $e \in L$. Altogether we get $\Pr(E_L) \leqslant p_{|L|}$, where

$$p_2 = c_1\,\tau^{*2}N^{-1}, \qquad p_3 = c_1\,\tau^* N^{-2}, \qquad p_4 = c_1\,\tau^* N^{-3}, \qquad c_1 = 2^{31}.$$

The event $E_L$ depends only on the variables $X_e$ with $e \in L$. Hence $E_L$ is mutually independent of the family of all events $E_{L'}$ with $L' \cap L = \emptyset$. We apply the local lemma in its general form [1, Lemma 5.1.1] with the weights $x_L = 2p_{|L|}$. Put $c_0 = 48c_1$. An edge $e$ lies in at most $n^{k-1}$ sets $L$ of size $k$. For $N \geqslant c_0 n\tau^{*2}$ this gives

$$\sum_{L \ni e} x_L \leqslant 2c_1\Big(\frac{n\tau^{*2}}{N} + \frac{n^2\tau^*}{N^2} + \frac{n^3\tau^*}{N^3}\Big) \leqslant \frac{6c_1}{c_0} = \frac{1}{8}.$$

In particular $x_L < 1$. Every set $L$ has at most 4 elements, so the weights of the sets $L'$ that meet $L$ sum to at most $\frac{1}{2}$. Thus

$$x_L \prod_{L' \cap L \neq \emptyset} (1 - x_{L'}) \geqslant x_L\Big(1 - \sum_{L' \cap L \neq \emptyset} x_{L'}\Big) \geqslant \frac{x_L}{2} = p_{|L|} \geqslant \Pr(E_L).$$

By the local lemma, with positive probability no event $E_L$ occurs. □

We now show that such columns give a configuration without obstructions, whatever the other singletons are. We state this for a window of columns, since for odd $h$ we will use several blocks with different sea rows.

**Lemma 33** (one block)**.** *Let $\mathcal{E}$ be a set of parity edges that are good for $g$, and let $(X_e)_{e\in\mathcal{E}}$ be integers such that $(X_e)_{e\in L}$ is not bad for any $L \subseteq \mathcal{E}$ with $2 \leqslant |L| \leqslant 4$. Let $I \subseteq \mathbb{Z}$ be an interval and let $B$ be a configuration with the following 3 properties for every column $x \in I$.*

*(1) If $x = X_e$ for some $e \in \mathcal{E}$, then column $x$ is black exactly in the 2 rows of $e$.*

*(2) If $x = X_e + a$ for some $e \in \mathcal{E}$ and $a \in A_e$, then column $x$ is black exactly in row 1 if $a < 0$, and exactly in row $g$ if $a > 0$.*

*(3) Otherwise column $x$ is black in exactly 1 point, which lies in row 1 or $g$.*

*Then $B$ contains no obstruction whose points all lie in columns of $I$.*

Since (B1) fails for all pairs, the columns $X_e$ are distinct, and (1) and (2) never apply to the same column or give 2 different rules for it. Note that the conditions (B1) to (B3) only depend on the differences of the columns, so they are not affected by a translation of all columns.

*Proof.* Let $Q$ be an obstruction in the columns of $I$ whose points are black. Let $L$ be the set of edges $e \in \mathcal{E}$ such that column $X_e$ contains a point of $Q$. By (1), a point of $Q$ in a column $X_e$ with $e \in L$ lies in a row of $e$. Every other point of $Q$ lies in a column that is not $X_f$ for any $f \in \mathcal{E}$, since otherwise $f \in L$. By (2) and (3), it is the only black point of its column and lies in row 1 or $g$.

Suppose first that $Q$ is a rival pair. Its 2 points lie in different columns. If $L$ is empty, this contradicts Lemma 27. If $L = \{e\}$, then $Q$ consists of a point $(X_e, c)$ with $c \in e$ and a point in row 1 or $g$, and its translate by $-X_e$ columns contradicts Lemma 31(c). If $L = \{e, f\}$, then $Q = \{(X_e, c), (X_f, c')\}$ with $c \in e$ and $c' \in f$, so (B2) holds for $L$.

Suppose now that $Q$ is a corner triple or a mixed quadruple. If $L$ is empty, this contradicts Lemma 27. Suppose that $|L| \geqslant 2$. Then $|L| \leqslant 4$, because $Q$ has at most 4 points. The columns $X_e$ with $e \in L$ are distinct, the first property in (B3) was shown at the start of the proof, and the second property is the definition of $L$. So (B3) holds for $L$, a contradiction. Suppose finally that $L = \{e\}$, and translate $Q$ by $-X_e$ columns to an obstruction $Q'$. Then $Q'$ is private to $e$. Hence every point of $Q'$ outside column 0 lies in a column $a \in A_e$, and the corresponding point of $Q$ lies in column $X_e + a$. This column is not a column $X_f$, so (2) applies to it, and by the paragraph before the proof (2) gives only one rule for it. So this point is in row 1 if $a < 0$ and in row $g$ if $a > 0$. Thus $Q'$ is contained in the gadget $G_e$, which contradicts Lemma 31(b). □

### 5.4 The constructions

We now build valid blackouts whose doubles carry a given set of parity edges. Recall the constant $c_0$ of Lemma 32.

**Proposition 34.** *Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a set of $n \geqslant 1$ parity edges on $h$ rows. In each of the following 3 cases there is, for every integer $m \geqslant M$, a valid blackout of the $h \times m$ grid with $m + n$ points.*

*(a) $h \geqslant 4$ is even, and $M = \lceil c_0\, n\, \tau^*(h)^2 \rceil$.*

*(b) $h \geqslant 5$ is odd, every edge of $\mathcal{F}$ is good for $h - 1$, and $M = \lceil c_0\, n\, \tau^*(h)^2 \rceil$.*

*(c) $h \geqslant 9$ is odd, and $M = c_0(n + 4)\, \tau^*(h)^2 + 6h^2 + 4$.*

*Proof. Cases (a) and (b).* Take $g = h$ in (a) and $g = h - 1$ in (b). Then $g$ is even and $2g - 1 > h$. In (a) every parity edge $\{r, s\}$ is good for $h$, since $\min(r - 1, h - g) = 0$. So in both cases the edges of $\mathcal{F}$ are good for $g$. Take the columns $X_e$ of Lemma 32 for $\mathcal{E} = \mathcal{F}$ and $N = M$. Let $B$ be the configuration in which column $X_e$ is black exactly in the 2 rows of $e$, column $X_e + a$ with $a \in A_e$ is black exactly in row 1 if $a < 0$ and exactly in row $g$ if $a > 0$, and every other column is black exactly in row 1. It satisfies the hypotheses

of Lemma 33 with $I = \mathbb{Z}$, so it contains no obstruction. For $m \geqslant M$ let $S$ be the set of points of $B$ in the columns 1 to $m$. Every column of $S$ is a singleton or a double. The doubles are the $n$ columns $X_e \leqslant M \leqslant m$, and their row pairs are the edges of $\mathcal{F}$. Hence $|S| = m + n$, and $S$ is valid by Lemma 25.

*Case (c).* Now Lemma 27 does not apply to the sea rows 1 and $h$. We use the 4 pairs of sea rows

$$\{1, h-1\}, \qquad \{1, h-3\}, \qquad \{2, h\}, \qquad \{4, h\}.$$

The last 2 are the images of the first 2 under the reflection $\rho(x, j) = (x, h + 1 - j)$. For odd $h$ this reflection maps parity edges to parity edges and obstructions to obstructions. Both $g = h - 1$ and $g = h - 3$ are even and satisfy $2g - 1 > h$, since $h \geqslant 9$.

We claim that for every parity edge $e = \{r, s\}$, with $r$ odd, one of $e$ and $\rho(e)$ is good for $h - 1$ or for $h - 3$. For $g = h - 1$, Definition 30 only involves $j = 1$. So $e$ is good for $h - 1$ unless $r = h$, or $r \geqslant 3$ and $h - r$ is a perfect square. Note that $h - r$ is even. Suppose that $h - r = 4u^2$ with $u \geqslant 1$ and that $s \leqslant h - 3$. Then $e$ lies in the rows 1 to $h - 3$, and for $g = h - 3$ the numbers $j(g - r + j)$ with $j = 1, 2, 3$ are

$$4u^2 - 2, \qquad 2(4u^2 - 1), \qquad 12u^2.$$

The first 2 are even and not divisible by 4, and the third is 3 times a square. None is a perfect square, so $e$ is good for $h - 3$. This leaves the edges with $r = h$ and the edges with $r = h - 4u^2 \geqslant 3$ and $s = h - 1$. If $r = h$, then $\rho(e)$ has the odd row 1 and is good for $h - 1$. In the last case $\rho(e) = \{1 + 4u^2, 2\}$, where $1 + 4u^2 \leqslant h - 2$. If $h - 1 - 4u^2$ is not a perfect square, then $\rho(e)$ is good for $h - 1$. Otherwise $h - (1 + 4u^2) = 4v^2$ with $v \geqslant 1$, and $\rho(e)$ is good for $h - 3$ by the computation above. This proves the claim.

By the claim we can split $\mathcal{F}$ into 4 sets $\mathcal{E}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{E}_4$, some of which may be empty, such that the edges of $\mathcal{E}_1$ are good for $g_1 = h - 1$, the edges of $\mathcal{E}_2$ are good for $g_2 = h - 3$, and the edges $\rho(e)$ with $e \in \mathcal{E}_3$ or $e \in \mathcal{E}_4$ are good for $g_3 = h - 1$ or $g_4 = h - 3$, respectively. Put $N_k = \lceil c_0 \max(|\mathcal{E}_k|, 1)\, \tau^*(h)^2 \rceil$, and define

$$s_1 = 1, \qquad s_{k+1} = s_k + N_k + 8W_h, \qquad z = s_3 - 4W_h.$$

If $\mathcal{E}_k$ is not empty, apply Lemma 32 with $g = g_k$ and $N = N_k$, to $\mathcal{E}_k$ for $k = 1, 2$ and to $\rho(\mathcal{E}_k)$ for $k = 3, 4$. In both cases we get columns $X_e \in \{1, \ldots, N_k\}$ for $e \in \mathcal{E}_k$. Define a configuration $B$ as follows.

- For $e \in \mathcal{E}_k$, column $x_e = s_k - 1 + X_e$ is black exactly in the 2 rows of $e$.
- For $e \in \mathcal{E}_k$ with $k \leqslant 2$ and $a \in A_e$, column $x_e + a$ is black exactly in row 1 if $a < 0$, and exactly in row $g_k$ if $a > 0$.
- For $e \in \mathcal{E}_k$ with $k \geqslant 3$ and $a \in A_{\rho(e)}$, column $x_e + a$ is black exactly in row $h$ if $a < 0$, and exactly in row $h + 1 - g_k$ if $a > 0$.
- Every other column $x$ is black exactly in row 1 if $x < z$, and exactly in row $h$ if $x \geqslant z$.

Put $U_k = [s_k - 2W_h,\, s_k + N_k - 1 + 2W_h]$ and $I_k = [s_k - 4W_h,\, s_k + N_k - 1 + 4W_h]$. By Lemma 31(a), the columns in the first 3 items for $\mathcal{E}_k$ lie in $U_k$. The intervals $I_1, \dots, I_4$ are disjoint, the intervals $I_1$ and $I_2$ lie to the left of column $z$, and $I_3$ and $I_4$ start at column $z$ or later. Hence $B$ is well defined, and in the columns of $I_k$ it satisfies the hypotheses of Lemma 33 for $k \leqslant 2$. For $k \geqslant 3$ the reflected configuration $\rho(B)$ satisfies them.

We show that $B$ contains no obstruction $Q$. Recall that $Q$ lies in $2W_h + 1$ consecutive columns. If $Q$ has a point in a column of some $U_k$, then $Q$ lies in the columns of $I_k$, which contradicts Lemma 33 for $B$ or for $\rho(B)$. Otherwise every point of $Q$ lies in row 1 and in a column $x < z$, or in row $h$ and in a column $x \geqslant z$. These points form a chain, so $Q$ is not a corner triple or a mixed quadruple by Lemma 28. It is not a rival pair by Lemma 26.

All doubles of $B$ lie in the columns 1 to $s_4 + N_4 - 1$, and

$$s_4 + N_4 - 1 = N_1 + N_2 + N_3 + N_4 + 24W_h \leqslant c_0(n+4)\,\tau^*(h)^2 + 4 + 6h^2 = M,$$

since $W_h \leqslant h^2/4$. For $m \geqslant M$ let $S$ be the set of points of $B$ in the columns 1 to $m$. As in the cases (a) and (b), the blackout $S$ is valid and has $m + n$ points. □

*Proof of Theorem 1(b).* By Theorem 16 we only need valid blackouts with $m + q_h$ points. For $h \leqslant 8$ they exist for $m \geqslant M_h$ by Proposition 3, so $m_h \leqslant M_h \leqslant M_8 = 211$. For $h \geqslant 9$ apply Proposition 34(a) or (c) to the set of all $q_h$ parity edges. The number $M$ in (c) need not be an integer, so this gives

$$m_h \leqslant c_0(q_h + 4)\,\tau^*(h)^2 + 6h^2 + 5 \qquad \text{for every } h \geqslant 9, \tag{2}$$

and both bounds are at most $C\,h^2\,\tau^*(h)^2$ with $C = c_0$. □

*Proof of Corollary 2.* We show the claim with $C' = 2c_0$. Let $n$ be the minimum in the claim. If $n = 0$, the claim is $f(h,m) \geqslant m$, which holds by Lemma 21. Let $n \geqslant 1$. Then $m \geqslant 2c_0\,n\,\tau^*(h)^2$. If $h \leqslant 8$, then $m \geqslant 2c_0 \geqslant 211 = M_8 \geqslant M_h$, and $f(h,m) = m + q_h$ by Proposition 3. If $h \geqslant 10$ is even, apply Proposition 34(a) to any $n$ parity edges. Let $h \geqslant 9$ be odd. An edge $\{r,s\}$ with $r$ odd is good for $h-1$ if $r \leqslant h-2$ and $h - r$ is not a perfect square. There are $\frac{h-1}{2}$ odd rows $r \leqslant h-2$, fewer than $\frac{1}{2}\sqrt{h}$ of them have $h - r = 4u^2$, and each odd row lies in $\frac{h-1}{2}$ parity edges. So at least $\frac{1}{4}(h - 1 - \sqrt{h})(h-1)$ parity edges are good for $h-1$, and this is at least $\frac{1}{8}(h^2-1) = \frac{1}{2}q_h$ because $h - 3 \geqslant 2\sqrt{h}$. If $n \leqslant \frac{1}{2}q_h$, apply Proposition 34(b) to $n$ edges that are good for $h-1$. If $n > \frac{1}{2}q_h$, apply Proposition 34(c) to any $n$ parity edges. Its condition on $m$ holds because

$$c_0\,n\,\tau^*(h)^2 \;\geqslant\; 4c_0\,\tau^*(h)^2 + c_0\big(\tfrac{1}{2}q_h - 4\big) \;\geqslant\; 4c_0\,\tau^*(h)^2 + 6h^2 + 4,$$

where the last step uses $\frac{1}{2}q_h - 4 = \frac{1}{8}(h^2 - 33)$, $h \geqslant 9$, and $c_0 \geqslant 100$. In every case we get $f(h,m) \geqslant m + n$. □

*Remark* 35 (constants and measured widths). The proof gives $c_0 = 3 \cdot 2^{35}$, which is about $10^{11}$, and we did not try to make it smaller. With this constant the bound (2) is first below the bound $M_h$ of Proposition 3 at $h = 710132287759$. The comparison is not monotone, since $\tau^*(h)$ jumps. For example (2) is again at least $M_h$ at $h = 757474440275$.

The construction itself is much better than its constant. We ran it with a greedy choice in place of the local lemma. The edges are taken in a random order, and each double gets the smallest column that is not bad together with the earlier ones, with (B1) to (B3) tested as defined. The best of 3 runs gave the widths below. Each blackout was then checked from Definition 5.

| $h$ | 12 | 13 | 14 | 16 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| width of the greedy blackout | 1180 | 1872 | 2154 | 2919 |
| $M_h$ | 1121 | 1559 | 2113 | 3655 |

For $h = 13$ the width includes 2 gaps of $8W_h = 296$ columns between the 3 blocks that occur. At $h = 16$ the conditions (B2) and (B3) matter. In 5 runs with only (B1) tested, all 5 blackouts were not valid.

*Remark* 36. By a theorem of Wigert [9, Theorem 317], the bound of Theorem 1(b) is $h^2 \exp\big(O(\log h/\log\log h)\big)$. The factor $\tau^*(h)^2$ comes from worst cases, while $\tau(n)$ is about $\log n$ on average. So averaged divisor sums [10] may replace $\tau^*(h)^2$ by a power of $\log h$. We do not prove this, and we do not know whether $m_h = O(h^2)$.

## 6 Small heights

We now prove Theorem 4. We describe a blackout by listing the black rows of its columns from left to right, so that $14, 45, 5$ has $B_1 = \{1, 4\}$ and $B_3 = \{5\}$.

### 6.1 Two, three, and four rows

*Proof of Theorem 4 for $h = 2, 3$.* By Lemma 9, a tilted rectangle meets at least 3 rows. So on 2 rows every rectangle is axis-aligned. Let $m \geqslant 3$. A cycle in $G_S$ needs 2 columns that are black in both rows. Hence, by Lemma 15, a blackout of the $2 \times m$ grid is valid if and only if at most 1 column is black in both rows. This gives $f(2, m) = m + 1$. For 3 rows, Theorem 16 gives $f(3, m) \leqslant m + 2$ and Lemma 21 gives $f(3, m) \geqslant m + 2$. □

On 4 rows, Lemma 9 gives $b + d \leqslant 3$. If $b = d = 1$, then $a = c = 1$, and the rectangle is a *diamond* $D(i, j)$ with corners $(i, j + 1)$, $(i + 1, j)$, $(i + 2, j + 1)$, and $(i + 1, j + 2)$, where $j \in \{1, 2\}$. Otherwise $\{b, d\} = \{a, c\} = \{1, 2\}$. This gives 4 rectangles $\mathsf{A}_i$, $\mathsf{B}_i$, $\mathsf{C}_i$, and $\mathsf{E}_i$ with one corner in each of the columns $i$ to $i + 3$, in the rows 3412, 3142, 2413, and 2143 from left to right.

**Proposition 37.** *For every $m \geqslant 6$ we have $f(4, m) = m + 4$.*

*Proof.* The upper bound is Theorem 16. For the lower bound take

$$S = \{(i, 1) : 2 \leqslant i \leqslant m - 1\} \cup \{(m - 1, 2), (m, 2), (1, 3), (2, 3), (1, 4), (m, 4)\}.$$

Then $|S| = m + 4$, and $G_S$ is the cycle $r_1\, c_2\, r_3\, c_1\, r_4\, c_m\, r_2\, c_{m-1}$ of length 8 with the leaves $c_3, \ldots, c_{m-2}$ at $r_1$. So $S$ is axis-valid by Lemma 15, and no axis-aligned rectangle is fully black.

A corner of a tilted rectangle in row 1 or 4 lies in a column from 2 to $m-1$, so it is black in row 1 and white in row 4. Checking the other corners, we find that $D(i,2)$, $\mathsf{C}_i$, and $\mathsf{E}_i$ have at most 1 black corner, and that the tilted rectangles with 2 or more black corners are those in the following table. Here $s=1$ for $\mathsf{A}_i$ and $s=2$ for $\mathsf{B}_i$.

| rectangle | which $i$ | white corners |
|---|---|---|
| $D(1,1)$ | | $(1,2),(3,2)$ |
| $D(i,1)$ | $i \in \{m-3, m-2\}$ | $(i,2),(i+1,3)$ |
| $\mathsf{A}_i$ or $\mathsf{B}_i$ | $i \in \{1,2\}$, $i \notin \{m-4, m-3\}$ | $(i+s,4),(i+3,2)$ |
| $\mathsf{A}_i$ or $\mathsf{B}_i$ | $i \in \{m-4, m-3\}$, $i \notin \{1,2\}$ | $(i,3),(i+s,4)$ |
| $\mathsf{A}_i$ or $\mathsf{B}_i$ | $i=2$, $m=6$ | $(i+s,4)$ |

The first 4 lines have different sets of rows. Within one line, the point in row 2 or 3 determines $i$, and the point in row 4 determines $s$. So these rectangles have distinct presentations.

It remains to show that no axis-aligned rectangle has one of these presentations. For $\{(1,2),(3,2)\}$ it would need a common black row of the columns 1 and 3, and there is none. In the next 3 lines the 2 white corners are opposite corners of one axis-aligned rectangle, and one of its other corners is white. This corner is $(i,3)$, $(i+s,2)$, or $(i,4)$, respectively, where we use $i \geqslant 3$, $i+s \leqslant 4 < m-1$, and $3 \leqslant i \leqslant m-3$. In the last line, the white corner is $(z,4)$ with $z \in \{3,4\}$. Column $z$ is black only in row 1, and no column is black in the rows 1 and 4. So no axis-aligned rectangle shows only $(z,4)$. □

*Proof of Theorem 4 for $h=4$.* By Proposition 37 it remains to treat the widths 4 and 5. Lemma 21 gives $f(4,4) \geqslant 7$ and $f(4,5) \geqslant 8$. By Theorem 19, a valid blackout with $m+4$ points has 4 doubles in different columns, on the edges of one of 3 cycles of length 4 on the rows, and a singleton in every other column. This leaves 72 candidates for $m=4$ and 1440 for $m=5$. A computer search finds 2 rectangles with the same presentation in each candidate. □

### 6.2 The finite collar theorem

We extend a finite blackout by columns that are black in one boundary row. For a blackout $S$ of the $h \times m$ grid and $\lambda, \mu \geqslant 0$, let $S_{\lambda,\mu}$ be the blackout on the columns $1-\lambda, \ldots, m+\mu$ that agrees with $S$ on the columns 1 to $m$ and whose other columns are black exactly in a fixed *padding row*, which is row 1 or row $h$.

**Theorem 38** (finite collar)**.** *Let $h \geqslant 3$ and let $S$ be a blackout of the $h \times m$ grid. Then $S_{\lambda,\mu}$ is valid for all $\lambda, \mu \geqslant 0$ if and only if $S_{W_h,W_h}$ is valid. Moreover $S_{0,\mu}$ is valid for all $\mu \geqslant 0$ if and only if $S_{0,W_h}$ is valid, and likewise for $S_{\lambda,0}$.*

*Proof.* We prove the first statement. The others are proved in the same way. Put $S^* = S_{W_h,W_h}$, suppose that $S^*$ is valid, and put $U = S_{\lambda,\mu}$. Call a tilted rectangle *weak* if it has 2 or more black corners. By (F1), a weak tilted rectangle of $U$ has a black corner outside the padding row, hence in a column $e$ with $1 \leqslant e \leqslant m$. Its span is at most $W_h$, so its

columns lie between $1 - W_h$ and $m + W_h$. Hence it is also a rectangle of the grid of $S^*$, with the same presentation there, since $U$ and $S^*$ agree on their common columns.

Suppose that distinct rectangles $R_1, R_2$ have the same presentation $P$ in $U$. By Lemma 7, $|P| \leqslant 2$.

*Both axis-aligned.* Every added column has degree 1 in $G_U$, so every cycle of $G_U$ lies in $G_{S^*}$. Since $S^*$ is valid and has 3 or more columns, Lemma 15 shows that $G_{S^*}$ has no cycle of length 4 or 6, and then that $U$ is axis-valid.

*Both tilted.* Both rectangles are weak, so both are rectangles of the grid of $S^*$ with the presentation $P$, which contradicts the validity of $S^*$.

*One of each.* Let $R_1$ be tilted. It is weak, so it lies in the grid of $S^*$. A column of $R_2$ that contains a point of $P$ is a column of $R_1$. A column of $R_2$ that contains no point of $P$ has 2 black corners, so it is one of the columns 1 to $m$. Thus $R_2$ also lies in the grid of $S^*$ and has the presentation $P$ there, again a contradiction. □

### 6.3 Five rows

Let $S_8$ be the blackout $14, 45, 25, 5, 5, 34, 23, 12$ of the $5 \times 8$ grid, and let $S_0$ be the blackout $45, 34, 123, 1, 15$ of the $5 \times 5$ grid. All validity claims below are finite checks from Definition 5 (Section 7).

*Proof of Theorem 4 for $h = 5$.* Let $m \geqslant 8$. The upper bound is Theorem 16. Since $W_5 = 5$, Theorem 38 with padding row 1 on the right reduces the lower bound to the validity of the test board $S_8, 1, 1, 1, 1, 1$ on the $5 \times 13$ grid. This board has 954 rectangles, and a direct check shows that their presentations are distinct.

For $m = 5$, Corollary 20 gives $f(5, 5) \leqslant 10$, and a direct check of its 130 rectangles shows that $S_0$ is valid. For $m = 6$ and $m = 7$ the blackouts $15, 12, 23, 3, 34, 45$ and $1, 12, 23, 3, 34, 45, 15$ are valid with $m + 5$ points, and checked SAT certificates exclude $m + 6$ points (Section 7). □

### 6.4 Six and seven rows

Let $S_{16}$ be the blackout $36, 14, 25, 6, 6, 16, 6, 6, 56, 45, 4, 4, 4, 34, 23, 12$ of the $6 \times 16$ grid. Its 9 doubles carry the edges of the complete bipartite graph between $\{1, 3, 5\}$ and $\{2, 4, 6\}$. To exclude blackouts with 1 point less than the row bound, we first find their row graphs.

**Lemma 39.** *Let $m \geqslant 3$, and let $S$ be an axis-valid blackout of the $6 \times m$ grid with $m + 8$ points. Then every column of $S$ is empty, a singleton, or a double, the doubles have distinct row pairs, and one of the following holds.*

*(a) No column is empty, and the pairs of the doubles are the edges of $K_{3,3}$ minus an edge.*

*(b) No column is empty, and the pairs of the doubles are the edges of $K_{2,4}$.*

*(c) Exactly 1 column is empty, and the pairs of the doubles are the edges of $K_{3,3}$.*

*Proof.* For every choice of the trees, Lemma 17 gives $|S| = t + e(H)$ with $t \leqslant m$, and $e(H) \leqslant 9$ by Lemma 18. So $(t, e(H))$ is $(m, 8)$ or $(m-1, 9)$. In the second case, the proof of Theorem 19 shows that $H$ is a $K_{3,3}$ and that no column has 3 black rows, which gives (c).

In the first case $H$ is triangle-free with 8 edges. If it were not bipartite, its shortest odd cycle would be a cycle of length 5 without chords. The sixth vertex is joined to at most 2 vertices of this cycle, so $e(H) \leqslant 7$, a contradiction. Hence $H$ is bipartite with parts of sizes $k$ and $6-k$, and $k(6-k) \geqslant 8$ shows that $H$ is $K_{2,4}$ or $K_{3,3}$ minus an edge. In both graphs, 2 vertices of the same part have 2 or more common neighbors. Suppose that $|B_i| \geqslant 3$. Then $T_i$ has a vertex $v$ with 2 neighbors $u$ and $w$. These lie in one part, so they have a common neighbor $z \neq v$. Replacing $vw$ by $uw$ in $T_i$ gives another tree on $B_i$ and the triangle $uwz$ in $H$, which contradicts Lemma 17. Thus every column is a singleton or a double, and the pairs of the doubles are the edges of $H$. □

There are 90 labeled graphs in case (a), 15 in case (b), and 10 in case (c).

*Proof of Theorem 4 for $h = 6$. Lower bounds.* The blackouts $14, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456$ of the $6 \times 6$ grid, $16, 1, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456$ of the $6 \times 7$ grid, and $15, 1, 123, 34, 4, 4, 456, 26$ of the $6 \times 8$ grid are valid with 12, 13, and 15 points. The blackout $12, 23, 34, 45, 6, 6, 36, 56, 25$ of the $6 \times 9$ grid has 16 points. Its test board with $W_6 = 7$ columns black only in row 1 on each side is valid, so Theorem 38 gives $f(6, m) \geqslant m + 7$ for every $m \geqslant 9$. For $12 \leqslant m \leqslant 14$ the blackout $16, 36, 25, 12, 1^{m-8}, 23, 34, 45, 56$ is valid with $m + 8$ points, where $1^k$ stands for $k$ columns black only in row 1. For $m = 15$ the blackout $56, 45, 34, 23, 1, 1, 14, 1, 1, 12, 36, 1, 25, 6, 16$ is valid with 24 points. For $m \geqslant 16$ we apply Theorem 38 to $S_{16}$ with padding row 1 on the right. Its test board on the $6 \times 23$ grid has 4627 rectangles with distinct presentations.

*Upper bounds.* Theorem 16 gives $f(6, m) \leqslant m + 9$. For $m = 6, 7, 8$, checked SAT certificates exclude 13, 14, and 16 points. Let $9 \leqslant m \leqslant 14$. A valid blackout with $m + 9$ points would have doubles on the edges of a $K_{3,3}$ by Theorem 19. Checked SAT certificates exclude each of the 10 choices of the $K_{3,3}$ (Section 7). Hence $f(6, m) \leqslant m + 8$. Let $9 \leqslant m \leqslant 11$. By Lemma 39, a valid blackout with $m + 8$ points has one of 115 row graphs. Checked SAT certificates exclude each of them, so $f(6, m) \leqslant m + 7$. □

*Proof of Theorem 4 for $h = 7$.* The blackouts $17, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456, 67$ of the $7 \times 7$ grid and $27, 367, 46, 2, 6, 24, 125, 16$ of the $7 \times 8$ grid are valid with 14 and 16 points, and checked SAT certificates exclude 15 and 17 points. Let $m \geqslant 24$. The row bound gives $f(7, m) \leqslant m + 12$. The file `papers/extremal/data/seven_row_blackouts.txt` of the repository [17] lists 5 blackouts of the widths 24 to 28 that are valid with $m + 12$ points. The one of width 28 stays valid after adding $W_7 = 10$ columns black only in row 7 on its left. Hence Theorem 38, with padding row 7 on the left, gives $m + 12$ points for every $m \geqslant 28$. □

*Remark* 40. In fact $f(7, m) = m + 12$ for every $m \geqslant 21$, so that $m_7 \leqslant 21$. The blackout $16, 36, 5, 25, 2, 2, 14, 7, 12, 27, 2, 7, 67, 7, 47, 7, 7, 56, 45, 34, 23$ of the $7 \times 21$ grid stays valid when it is extended by 3 columns black only in row 1 and then by any number of columns

black only in row 2. Theorem 38 does not apply to row 2. The supplement proves a variant for this tail, which reduces all widths to a check of the width 45.

## 7 Computer checks

The computer-assisted entries of Table 1 need 2 kinds of finite checks. The repository [17] contains the code and the evidence files. Its supplement `papers/extremal/supplement.pdf` describes the SAT encodings, proves that they are faithful, and lists the instances, the certificates, and the formal proofs.

**Lower bounds.** Every blackout and test board of Section 6 was checked from Definition 5 by at least 2 separately written programs, which list all rectangles and compare their presentations. One of them is the script `papers/extremal/scripts/check_constructions.py`. It also checks the blackouts of Proposition 22 for $3 \leqslant h \leqslant 8$ and the greedy blackouts of Remark 35 for $4 \leqslant h \leqslant 14$ and $h = 16$. For $h = 5$ and $h = 7$ the script uses 2 blocks with the sea rows $\{1, h-1\}$ and $\{2, h\}$. No proof in this paper covers this variant, since Proposition 34(c) needs $h \geqslant 9$. These 2 heights are extra tests. At $h = 16$ all 3 blackouts built with (B1) to (B3) are valid, and all 5 blackouts built with (B1) alone are not valid. So the script tests the conditions on 2 or more doubles.

**Upper bounds.** Each upper bound below the row bound is the unsatisfiability of SAT instances. CaDiCaL [3] produced an LRAT proof for each of the 739 instances, and each proof was accepted by 2 checkers, the program `lrat-check` of drat-trim [5, 20] and the LRAT checker of the Lean core library.

**Formal proofs.** A Lean development in the repository proves the row bound, the finite collar theorem, Proposition 22 under the stronger assumption $p_{j+1} - p_j \geqslant 2W_h + 2$, and the values $f(5, m) = m + 6$ for $m \geqslant 8$ and $f(6, m) = m + 9$ for $m \geqslant 15$. The spacing $W_h + 1$ and Section 5 are not formalized.

## 8 Square grids

On the $n \times n$ grid the row bound is of order $n^2$ and is far from the truth. For $n \geqslant 3$, Lemma 15 and Neuwirth's bound for bipartite graphs of girth 8 with $n$ vertices on each side [15, Corollary 16] give $f(n, n) < n^{4/3} + \frac{2}{3}\, n$, which is the right order for axis-aligned rectangles alone [2]. With tilted rectangles we only have the following lower bound.

*Remark* 41. There is a constant $c > 0$ such that $f(n, n) \geqslant c\, n^{6/5}(1 + \ln n)^{-2/5}$ for every $n \geqslant 2$. We only sketch the proof, which is the deletion method [1, Section 3.2]. By Lemmas 6, 7, and 8, a blackout is valid if it contains no corner set of a rectangle, no support of a mixed pair, and no set $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ for rectangles with exactly 1 common corner. With $\Lambda = 1 + \ln n$, there are at most $K n^{4+1/10} \Lambda$ sets of the first 2 kinds, with 4 points each, and at most $32 n^6 \Lambda^2$ sets of the third kind, with 6 points each. Choose each point independently with probability $192^{-1/5} n^{-4/5} \Lambda^{-2/5}$, and delete 1 point from each of

these sets whose points are all chosen. The expected number of remaining points is of order $n^{6/5}\Lambda^{-2/5}$.

## 9 Open problems

(1) *The order of the threshold.* Theorem 1 gives $q_h \leqslant m_h \leqslant h^{2+o(1)}$. Is $m_h = O(h^2)$? The known values are $m_4 = 6$, $m_5 = 8$, and $m_6 = 15$, and $m_7 \leqslant 21$ (Remark 40). What is $m_7$, and what is $f(7, m)$ for $9 \leqslant m \leqslant 20$?

(2) *A lower bound.* The bound $m_h \geqslant q_h$ only counts the doubles. Is there a constant $c > 1$ with $m_h \geqslant c\, q_h$ for all large $h$? Does $m_h/q_h$ tend to infinity?

(3) *Monotonicity.* Is $f(h, m+1) \geqslant f(h, m) + 1$ for all $h \geqslant 2$ and $m \geqslant 3$? It would imply that the widths with $f(h, m) = m + q_h$ are exactly the widths $m \geqslant m_h$. We could not even prove that $f(h, m)$ is nondecreasing in $m$.

(4) *Square grids.* What is the order of growth of $f(n, n)$, between $n^{6/5-o(1)}$ and $n^{4/3}$? Theorem 4 gives $f(n, n) \leqslant 2n$ for $n \leqslant 7$. What is the first $n$ with $f(n, n) > 2n$?

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